Dutch possessions in the East Indies. Raffles played a leading role in these events, and we get a wonderful insight into the man and the times from the letters he sent back to Calcutta for Lord Minto and other senior officials. It is amazing that, in the middle of organizing military operations and administrative systems in far-flung islands, people like Raffles found the time to study the flora and fauna, record local customs and investigate ancient ruins.

After Napoleon was defeated, the Dutch wanted their colonies back. There were heated negotiations between Calcutta and Batavia (the Dutch headquarters, now Jakarta). The Dutch would eventually get back most of their possessions as per the Anglo–Dutch Treaty of 1824, but not before Stamford Raffles had ensured that the British would retain effective control of the Straits of Malacca. The key to his strategy was the establishment of a new British outpost in Singapore. The island had been under the nominal control of the Sultan of Johore but Raffles was able to secure it in exchange for the payment of an annual rent and British support against the Sultan's local rival. Singapore was formally founded on 6 February 1819 with a great deal of pomp and the firing of cannons. Raffles wrote, 'I shall say nothing of the importance of the position I have taken in Singapore; it is a child of my own … Our object is not territory but trade; a great commercial emporium, and a fulcrum, whence we may extend our influence politically as circumstances may hereafter require'. [3]

Raffles is remembered mostly as the founder of Singapore, but his writings show an extraordinary curiosity about the natural and cultural history of South East Asia. He avidly collected samples of plants and animals and even sent back a Sumatran tapir for the Governor General's garden in Barrackpore. He wrote extensively about the Indianized culture of Java and Bali, and is said to have 'rediscovered' the great stupa of Borobodur during the British occupation of Java. I wonder if he ever saw the panel carved with the windblown ship—a memory of an earlier age of mercantile trade. Just before he returned to England, Raffles set up an institute in Singapore inspired by Calcutta's Fort William College. It survives as the Raffles Institution, an elite school, although its original